

The Actor Who Felt Like an Outsider--Just Like Mozart!

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Have you ever felt like you don't quite fit in? Actor Will Sharpe knows that feeling well. He grew up moving between Japan and England, and he says he never felt like he completely belonged anywhere. "If I go back to Japan, I can speak the language, but kind of in a very **wobbly** way," he says. That's why he was perfect to play Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart in the new TV series Amadeus.

Mozart was a musical genius who lived hundreds of years ago. But in the show, he's shown as a bit of an **oddball**someone who doesn't understand social rules and often says the wrong thing. Sharpe thinks Mozart might have been what we'd call **neurodivergent** today, meaning his brain worked a little differently. "He doesn't know how to **read a room**," Sharpe explains. "Things that are simple to everyone else he can't do."

To get ready for the role, Sharpe spent months learning piano pieces and how to **conduct** an **orchestra**. He wanted to show that Mozart's music didn't just magically appearit took hard work. "There's this sense that music just fell out of the sky into his lap," Sharpe says. "But I was curious: What does that actually look and feel like in his day-to-day life?"

Sharpe has been in lots of cool shows, like The White Lotus and a movie with Kieran Culkin. But playing Mozart let him use his own feelings of being an outsider to create someone truly unforgettable.

Word Treasure

neurodivergent -- Neurodivergent means having a brain that works in a different way, like in autism or ADHD.

orchestra -- An orchestra is a large group of musicians who play instruments like violins, cellos, and trumpets together.

conduct -- To conduct an orchestra means to lead the musicians by waving a baton so they play at the right speed and loudness.

wobbly -- Wobbly means shaky or unsteady, like a chair with one short leg.

oddball -- An oddball is someone who acts in a strange or unusual way and doesn't quite fit in.

read a room -- To read a room means to understand the mood or feelings of a group of people just by looking and listening.

Background you need

Will Sharpe is a British-Japanese actor who grew up between two cultures and has starred in 'The White Lotus', a show about guests at a fancy hotel.

Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756-1791) was one of the world's most famous composers, writing over 600 pieces of music before he died at age 35.

Kieran Culkin (known for the TV series 'Succession') co-starred with Sharpe in a movie, adding to Sharpe's reputation as a versatile actor.

The term neurodivergent is used today to describe people whose brains work differently, like those with autism or ADHD; some experts think Mozart might have been like that, which could explain his social struggles but also his genius.

Break it down

WHO: Will Sharpe, an actor who felt like an outsider growing up between Japan and England

WHAT: He stars as Mozart in 'Amadeus', using his own loneliness to portray the oddball composer

WHERE: The show is set in the 18th century, and Sharpe prepared by learning piano and conducting in London

WHY: To show that even a musical genius had trouble fitting in, and how hard work -- not just talent -- created his music

Why it matters

Sharpe's story shows that feeling different can be turned into a strength, and that mastering any skill takes practice -- a lesson for anyone who sometimes feels like they don't fit in.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Will Sharpe grow up moving between?
 - (A) Japan and Canada
 - (B) Japan and England
 - (C) England and France
 - (D) Japan and the USA
2. Who does Sharpe play in the TV series Amadeus?
 - (A) A modern musician
 - (B) Kieran Culkin
 - (C) Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart
 - (D) A Japanese emperor
3. What does Sharpe think Mozart might have been today?
 - (A) A scientist
 - (B) Neurodivergent
 - (C) A football player
 - (D) A king
4. What did Sharpe learn to do to prepare for the role?
 - (A) Sing opera
 - (B) Dance
 - (C) Play piano and conduct an orchestra
 - (D) Paint landscapes
5. Which popular TV show is Sharpe known for besides Amadeus?
 - (A) Game of Thrones
 - (B) The White Lotus
 - (C) Stranger Things
 - (D) Succession
6. How does Sharpe describe his ability to speak Japanese?
 - (A) Perfectly
 - (B) Fluently
 - (C) In a very wobbly way
 - (D) With a strong accent

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Sharpe's own view:** He believes Mozart was likely neurodivergent and that his music was the result of intense hard work, not magic.
2. **Excited fan:** Viewers of 'Amadeus' get to see a famous composer as a real, flawed person, making his story more relatable and human.
3. **Careful historian:** Some may argue we can't know for sure if Mozart was neurodivergent without more proof, but the show starts interesting discussions about brain differences.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):